

KF10 Meeting Version of Teachings

Karis is an invitation to a relationship based on mutual generosity.

“Search me, O God, and know my heart. Examine me and know my thoughts. See if there is any way in me that causes pain, and lead me in the ways of eternity.” (Psalm 139:23–24)

0:01 OPENING

0:02 PRESENTING

0:06 KARIS CIRCULATION

0:07 GUIDELINES & LIMITATIONS

0:08 MINDFULNESS & MEDITATION TRAINING

Dr. Thorndyke, a character in detective fiction created about a hundred years ago, defined mindfulness as *the capacity for continuous observation and a habit of allowing nothing to pass without a certain amount of conscious attention*.¹ In KF, we begin our mindfulness training by observing our breath. Then, as we continue to train, we learn to expand our capacity for continuous observation to include everything, both within and without, as we go through our day.

Centuries ago, some jealous teachers questioned a great teacher about the difference between his disciples and theirs. They said, “Our disciples walk, and so do yours. They eat, as yours do. What is the difference?” The great teacher answered, “This is the difference. My disciples *know* that they are walking and they *know* that they are eating.”² By this he meant that his disciples were consciously aware of their movements and choices. They had learned to stop damaging things, forgetting things, going on autopilot, and messing things up, because they had learned the habit of allowing nothing to pass without a certain amount of conscious attention. We can learn to live like that, too.

Let’s practice the **Maranatha Meditation**.³

Begin by sitting still and as upright as you can. Breathe as you lightly close your eyes. *(Pause)* Your mind may not be focused right now, but don’t worry about that. It’s better to try to meditate and to do it imperfectly than to give up meditation because you can’t do it without some frustration. Meditation is a discipline that requires training and practice. Be kind to yourself as a learner.

Continue your mindful observation of the breath as within yourself you begin to say the word MAA-RAA-NAA-THAA. If your mind wanders, gently draw it back to the word and the breath. *(Pause)* To help you endure, I will remind you of the word once during our three-minute meditation. Begin, and relax into the word as you breathe. *(Pause for 3 minutes with a reminder of the word after 1.5 minutes)*

And pause. Your breath can function as an anchor to bring you into a present state of awareness without judgment. The **Maranatha Meditation** trains your mind to stop dashing around out of fear or euphoria.

You learn to take charge of your body and your mind when your Idol Self feels the compelling need to fulfill its search for glory.

Our hymn and prayer is *Teach Me Thy Way, O Lord*.

Long as my life shall last, teach me Thy way!
Where'er my lot be cast, teach me Thy way!
Until the race is run, until the journey's done,
Until the crown is won, teach me Thy way!⁴

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about this training?")

0:20 KARIS CONFESSION

0:21 TOOLBOX

This month we are exploring KF Confession 2:

We abandoned the glory that was ours, designed for us by our Creator.

Over the past few weeks, we have been looking at the **Two Paths Flowchart**. This tool helps us think through how we, or others, are handling an event. If we have taken the judgment path, we have reacted with fear, but it might not feel like fear at the time. Fear might feel like fatigue, rage, or an addictive compulsion. When examining your experiences and reactions, it is important to remember that the event itself is not causing the fear. The event is only revealing the fear that is already there, the fear that you already carry. Nancy has designed a guide called the **Two Paths Worksheet** to help you apply the flowchart to an event. You might like to print it out and explore it this week.

As we learn to recognize and unload our fears, we become more and more aware of the areas where we cannot trust ourselves. You might review the chapter on your Idol type in Dr. Horney's book, as well as chapters 12–16, to help you identify the situations that tempt you to react with fear, making you untrustworthy. Your fear reactions are based on your personal law, your "Ten Commandments". They are the shoulds, taboos, and claims that enslave you to the fear of death. God's commandments are healthy and support our true glory, but our personal commandments compel us to save our Idol's life and, with it, our pride. We need to reclaim the treasure of the glory that has been stolen from us by our Idol's fear.

Our fears fall into three general categories—the fear of self, the fear of others, and the fear of loss, including the loss of control.

First, we fear ourselves. We fear that something is wrong with us and that this fundamental wrongness will inexorably ruin our lives. Deep down, we know that we can destroy our lives, but the fatal flaw is to believe that we cannot help it. The truth is that we actually can make choices that will produce positive outcomes.

Second, we fear people, God, or institutions. Some of us fear that others will outshine us, obstruct us, or shame us. We are afraid that they will not support us in our efforts to fulfill our imagined glory. Some of us fear that others will abandon us, reject us, or judge us. Their opinion of us is critical to our well-being.

When others are stronger or quicker than we are, we may fear that they will impose on us and make us do things we don't want to do.

The last general category of fear is the fear of loss. We may fear the loss of a loving relationship, a lifestyle, freedom, control, wealth of any kind, or even the loss of a sense of superiority. We are terrified of losing whatever our Idol Self values, whether mastery, love, or freedom. We are afraid that time and resources will be stolen from us. We fear the loss of our true potential.

Most of the fears that KF members identified were fears of self. This is typical of KF members and is actually quite positive. It means that you have a reasonable fear of how powerful your choices can be. You may not know how to manage those choices right now, but you are in KF because you have hope that you can learn. You are willing to be trained and are making the effort to learn courage and endurance. You are far, far above the average person in your efforts to change your life.

The Idol Self conscripts our natural fears, which are designed to promote survival, and uses those fears to defend itself when threatened. Fear is an extremely powerful motivator, and it is the only motivator that the Idol Self knows how to use. Over the years, your body has adapted to using fear as its primary motivator in all kinds of situations. You are now so accustomed to living in fear that you may be afraid to give it up; the idea of a life free from fear may actually frighten you. What will help you make choices if not fear? What will you use to justify your compulsive need to attack, appease, medicate, or withdraw? You may tell yourself the story that your misoriented choices are motivated by common sense, justice, a real need, or Christian obedience, but, in reality, they are motivated by fear. For all of us, fear is difficult both to acknowledge and to give up.

Continue to use the **Tapping Protocol** when you recognize that fear is motivating you. Through tapping you can relieve the aching need to fight or control, lie or apologize, escape or block. Calm your distress as you would calm a distressed child.

In our next lesson, we will learn how to use the **Two Paths Worksheet**, which helps us analyze our reactions to people and events, and guides us to creatively consider our options. You might wish to explore this worksheet with your Karis Link.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Loving Lord, help me in the moment to recognize the fear. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Toolbox?")

0:30 SHARING

1:00 BIBLE TEACHING

If you have your Bible with you, turn to the second chapter of Paul's letter to the Philippians.

In this letter, Paul wants to remind us of the glory that we abandon when we choose the Idol Self over the real God. The Bible tells us what our glory looks like and feels like, and it describes the results of living in that glory, but we don't believe what the Bible says. We have not been encouraged or trained to

understand that our true glory can be experienced now, today, here on earth. The problem is a little more sinister than that, however. We have imagined a glory that we think is better than the one designed for us by our Creator. It takes humility and courage to give up the pursuit of fulfilling our imagined glory and, like Jesus, to take up the form of a servant and pursue our real glory.

This is Nancy's translation with paraphrase of **Philippians 2:5–11**.

⁵Think within yourselves as Christ Jesus did,⁶who, though in the form of God from the beginning, led the way in not grasping for that prize of equal footing with God. ⁷Instead, He stripped and emptied Himself of the form of God and took the form of a slave, becoming just like other people with creaturely limitations, and was discovered by everyone to look just like a human being. ⁸He humbled Himself, becoming obedient right up to His death, the death of the cross, perhaps the humblest death of all. ⁹Therefore, God super-exalted Him, much more than Jesus could have exalted Himself, and God *karissed* to Jesus the Name above all names—that is, His own reputation and authority, perhaps God's greatest gift—¹⁰in order that at the name of Jesus every knee should bow, the knees of every heavenly and earthly being and of those in the underworld, ¹¹and every tongue should make grateful acknowledgements, with the giving of thanks, that the Lord, the Name above all names, is Jesus Christ; and all of this adds to the glory of God the Father.

Take a deep breath.

If we will choose to cultivate the same attitude of humility that Jesus had, we can follow Him to real glory. Jesus really was God, but unlike our Idol, He did not snatch at being God. Instead, He chose to be a bondservant and allowed others to experience Him as a simple human being. If we want to follow Him, we will have to come down from the lofty illusions of our imagined glory and become obedient to God to the point of what often feels like death—for that is what it takes. Obedience will feel very much like the death of our idealized dreams of personal fulfillment, but when our training in humility is complete, we will experience a resurrection just as Jesus did. God will take over the exalting part and will help you, even you, to become more than you ever dreamed possible. This is not just storytelling. We see it happening in Karis Fellowships every week.

In our last lesson, we learned that when we live out of the True Self, several things happen:

1. We live in continual correspondence, or circulation, with the created world and the Creator.
2. We become truly creative creatures who are bringing the glory of God into the material and spiritual world.
3. We explore what Paul meant when he wrote to Timothy: "The mature outcome of our message is love from a clean heart and mind, from a good moral co-understanding with God, and an authentic, active trust."⁵

Through the Holy Spirit living in us, the True Self has been birthed by God, our true Father; and when we produce the Fruit of the Spirit in our lives, we reveal our new family heritage. We can learn to nurture the production of this Fruit, just as we can learn to nurture the produce of a garden.

When fruit is ripe, the harvest feeds us and everyone around us.⁶ However, producing fruit, whether in a garden or in our lives, does not happen overnight. A harvest of fruit requires the intentional and consistent investment of preparation, training, time, and resources. The real business of the True Self is to provide an environment that eventually produces the Fruit of the Spirit in every situation. You are a new creation in Christ. You are no longer compelled to conform to the world with all of its conflicts, fears, and cravings, nor are you obligated to adhere to old family systems that promote and maintain futile ways of life. You don't have to perpetuate the fears, misoriented choices, and secrets of your forefathers.⁷ Nothing changed until Jesus came to do something new. Now, you are doing something new. It's not easy to do new things, but nothing will change unless you do.

Our prayer might go something like this:

Lord and Creator, help me become something new. (Repeat)

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, "Does anyone have comments or questions about the Bible teaching?")

1:10 INTEGRATION

Sip some purified water and prepare to take some notes. Assume your mindfulness posture, and breathe. *(Pause for 10 seconds)*

Here is our integration focus: *Consider choosing to become something new. (Repeat) (Pause for 30 seconds)*

The FAITH Process

Feelings

As you *consider choosing to become something new*, how does it feel? *(Pause)* Your feelings are yours to teach you about yourself, to guide you, and to train you. They can often be uncomfortable. *(Pause)* Recognize with compassion whatever you are feeling, and breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Awareness without judgment

Allow whatever you are experiencing to rest in your awareness, without judgment. You might notice a compulsion to push thoughts or feelings away, to judge them, or to justify them. We often flush feelings or thoughts from our awareness before they have a chance to teach us. Breathe, and hold your experience up to the light as you *consider becoming something new. (Pause for 30 seconds)*

Inquiry: What is my body saying?

Bring your attention to your body. Notice what it is doing when you *consider becoming something new*. What sensations are there? *(Pause)* Your body is always talking to you. You may not understand its language right now, but you can observe. For example, you might recognize what hopelessness, terror, or inspiration feels like in your body. Breathe. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Talk to Jesus

You might imagine that you are leaning back in the safe and loving arms of Jesus as together you *consider becoming something new*. Does that feel comfortable, uncomfortable, or are you shutting down? Just observe. *(Pause)* Do you judge becoming something new as good or evil, as liberty or threat? *(Pause)* What

are your reasons? What story do you want to tell? *(Pause)* Are you afraid of something—of loss, of others, or of yourself? *(Pause)* Observe your responses as just information, and breathe with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

Heal

God created us to have all of these feelings, and for thousands of years human beings have been feeling like you feel when they have *considered becoming something new*. You are not alone in your feelings. You are a human creature. *(Pause)* Breathe with compassion for yourself and for others who are making an effort to become something new. Help your body process with a long exhaling breath. *(Pause for 30 seconds)*

(Optional) Continue to breathe while I test for further integration.

Pause. Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about the integration?”)

1:28 ENDING PRAYER

Dear Father and Creator,

Thank You for this time to heal and train together. Hold us in the power of this new understanding as You guide us to our real glory and to the truth. Lead us to the next step in our healing this week as we co-labor with You to reorient our lives for a more effective flow and to flourish in our connection with our True Self, with the Creation, and with You, for the glory and honor of our Lord Jesus. Amen.

Take a deep breath.

(If time permits, ask, “Does anyone have comments or questions about this meeting?”)

1:29 ANNOUNCEMENTS

¹ R. Austin Freeman, *The Red Thumb Mark* (London: Collingwood Brothers, 1907), chapter XIII. Accessed 18 June, 2016, gutenberg.net.au/ebooks/c00002.html.

² Nhat Hanh, Thich. *The Long Road Turns to Joy: A Guide to Walking Meditation* (Berkeley: Parallax Press, 1996), 4.

³ John Main, *Monastery without Walls: The Spiritual Letters of John Main*, ed. Laurence Freeman (London: Canterbury Press Norwich, 2006), 32.

⁴ *Teach Me Thy Way, O Lord* by Benjamin Mansell Ramsey (1849–1923), youtu.be/FmY6848ZQeo.

⁵ 1 Tim. 1:5 (translated with paraphrase by Nancy Diven).

⁶ Gal. 5:22–23.

⁷ 2 Cor. 5:17; 1 Peter 1:18.